

https://secure.storage

Keeping your data online is an attractive and viable storage alternative for individuals as well as businesses

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When online storage services were in a nascent stage, they only offered basic services such as uploading via a Web interface, and often, the services were slow and cumbersome. The services have evolved fast, though, and a lot of recently-launched services offer new-age features such as data encryption, file tagging, public sharing, RSS feed support, and most importantly, many of them are free!

As a small business or a SoHo setup, you'll be interested in online storage for primarily three reasons—first, the fact that even backups on DVD do not entirely guarantee data safety. With online storage, you can pretty much be 100 per cent sure your data will be safe. Second, if you need to exchange data with national and international clients, having the data available on the Web is very convenient indeed. Besides, some of your employees could be working from home, and having their data available online is again convenient.

Here, we'll be looking at Box.net, Apple's .Mac, Jungle Disk, Omnidrive, Streamload, and Openomy. This is not an exhaustive list: there are other services such as Xdrive and GoDaddy that can be considered.

Box.net

Box.net (www.box.net) offers a clean though somewhat flashy interface. You can sign up for a free 1 GB account, or buy a 5 GB account for \$4.99 (approx Rs 225) a month with a bandwidth cap of 20 GB per month. If your requirements exceed this, there is also a 15 GB account for \$9.99 (Rs 450) a month, with a bandwidth cap of 50 GB per month.

With the free account, there is also a 10 MB cap on the size of the files you can upload.

The service only allows for uploading via a Web interface, but they're launching a desktop client soon. It supports most browsers including IE, Firefox, Safari, and Opera. We created an account and did a trial run, and we didn't encounter any problems with these browsers.

The "Box Desktop", soon to be launched, will enable you to save and sync files to your Box.net account from your desktop. Box.net offers their API to developers so they can integrate and utilise Box.net's storage service in their applications.

With an account at Box.net, you get a slew of features including drag and drop support, file tagging, and RSS feeds so you can receive updates on the files you upload. You can also post, on your blog or Web site, pictures, movies and other files hosted on Box.net. The service lets you share files with others. If you make any file or folder public, you will get a URL for that file or folder so that others can access it anywhere. However, this is a premium feature. Users with a free account can only share files with other Box.net users.

Also provided is optional shell access for data transfer. Shell or SSH is a network protocol that allows for sharing of files between a local and a remote computer. It means more security, since the transmitted data is encrypted.

Features such as tagging help you organise your files better so you can retrieve the files at a later date without hassles. Being an ad-free service is an added plus for Box.net.

The actual cost comes to around \$0.001/MB per month for the 5 GB account and \$0.0006/MB per month for the 15 GB account—very impressive. Help and support is offered via e-mail and a set of FAQs.

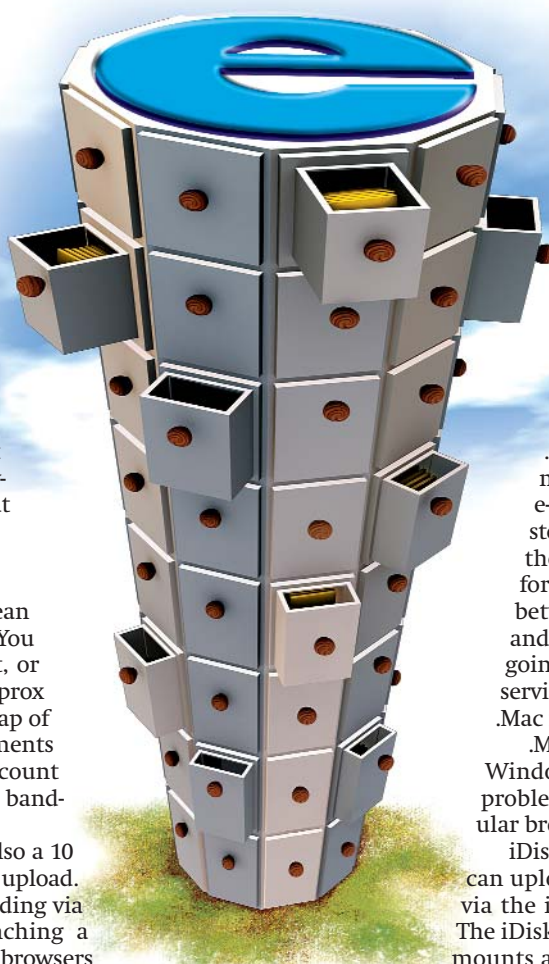
Apple .Mac

.Mac (www.mac.com) is about much more than just online storage—it is an e-mail plus hosting plus syncing plus storage service. All this comes at a price though—you pay \$99 (Rs 5,600) per year for 1 GB of space. This space is divided between e-mail and iDisk (the hosting and online storage). If you aren't sure of going ahead and spending so much on a service you haven't used, you can try out .Mac for 60 days for free.

.Mac offers cross-platform support with Windows and OS X. We did not face any problems accessing the service using popular browsers, on Windows as well as Mac.

iDisk is a feature-rich storage service. You can upload files via a Web browser, and also via the iDisk utility for Windows and OS X. The iDisk utility is unique in the sense that it mounts as a drive on your computer. You can save items to your local iDisk drive even when your Net connection is down; then, whenever your computer connects to the Internet, the local drive synchronises with the server, and your files are uploaded.

.Mac's features list is impressive: Web site hosting, iCards—a service that offers online cards for various occasions, discussion groups, bookmarks and system synchronisation (you can syn-



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